



Types of crosses in 2026 World Cup

Inswing

427

Outswing

1007

Driven

179

Lofted

335

Cutback

105

Push cross

510

Magical touch: Lionel Messi delivers an outswinging cross during Argentina's World Cup semifinal win over England, setting up Lautaro Martinez's winning goal. GETTYIMAGES

for 105 minutes. In a World Cup that marked the resurgence of traditional wing play, it was fitting that a cross provided the defining moment in the final for Spain, the tournament's top-crossing side (178).

Crossing proved to be one of the tournament's defining attacking weapons. Of the 308 goals scored, 75 came from open-play crosses, a rate of almost one in every four. Outswinging crosses were the preferred choice, with 1,007 of the 2,563 attempted crosses curved away from goal.

Their impact was evident, with several crucial goals following this crossing pattern. Lautaro Martinez's winner for Argentina against England in the semifinal, Erling Haaland's opener for Norway against Brazil, Enzo Fernandez's stoppage-time winner against Egypt

and Jude Bellingham's opening goal for England against Mexico, all in the Round of 16, came from outswinging crosses.

Argentina was perhaps the biggest beneficiary of this weapon. It attempted just 11 crosses across its opening three group games, slicing through opponents with its slick passing football.

In the knockouts, the game state necessitated a greater reliance on crosses. Across the five matches that followed, Argentina ramped up its crossing, averaging 13 per game, particularly against Egypt, Switzerland and England, despite not having a traditional marksman up front.

Ten-man England survived an onslaught of crosses against Mexico in the final 40 minutes before cutting the supply to Haaland in the

quarterfinal. Against Argentina, however, Thomas Tuchel opted to crowd the penalty area and repel the crosses. Argentina's relentless drive, coupled with the genius of Lionel Messi, ultimately proved to be England's undoing. Messi delivered the perfect outswinging cross across the face of the goal for Martinez to thump home the winning header.

"They won every header. They kept crossing and crossing. So we went to a back five to close the gaps inside and be stronger in the air. Straight after our goal, with no substitutions, we just conceded way too many crosses and way too many chances," Tuchel lamented.

In the final, however, Argentina and Messi were starved of the ball by Spain. Argentina registered just four open-play crosses, three of which came in the final five minutes as it desperately tried to claw its way back, but to no avail.

By then, however, Porro's cross had already had the final say for Spain.